

READING NOTES

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1. INTRODUCTION

The motivation behind this running record of reading notes on mathematics is to gather the ongoing observations, ideas and questions which arise during my study. The entries are primarily for my own understanding, but I hope they may also be of interest to others who enjoy exploring mathematics. As my understanding evolves, some notes may be revised in the future.

2. NOTES

15th Aug, 2026. This day was mostly spent in trying to understand and revisit some topics in mathematics (from varied fields). I am summarising some of them below.

- (1) For a polynomial p , the equation $p(x) = a$ has only finitely many real solutions unless p is identically a . These finitely many roots divide $\mathbb{R}$ into finitely many intervals on which $p(x) - a$ has a fixed sign.
- (2) A space X is connected if it cannot be written as the union of two disjoint nonempty open subsets. An important result is that the continuous image of a connected space is connected.
- (3) If a set can be written as $S = \{\gamma(t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}$ for a continuous map $\gamma : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$, then S is connected, since $\mathbb{R}$ itself is connected.
- (4) When $a^m = b^n$, $\gcd(m, n) = 1$, the coprimality allows a and b to be expressed as powers of a common quantity: $a = t^n$, $b = t^m$.
This is useful for turning an algebraic relation into a one-parameter parametrization.
- (5) If X is a finite set with n elements, then every function $X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous when X has the discrete topology. Hence $C(X, \mathbb{R}) \cong \mathbb{R}^n$, so its dimension is n .
- (6) The divisors of an integer m usually occur in pairs $d, m/d$. The only time a divisor is paired with itself is when $d = m/d$, which gives $m = d^2$. Thus an integer has an odd number of divisors exactly when it is a perfect square.
- (7) Double counting means constructing a set of objects and counting that same set in two different ways. Since both counts give the cardinality of the same set, they must be equal.
- (8) For a matrix A , if $Av = \lambda v$, then $A^k v = \lambda^k v$. Consequently, for a convergent power series f , $f(A)v = f(\lambda)v$, so the eigenvalues of $f(A)$ are obtained by applying f to the eigenvalues of A .
- (9) For a sequence of functions $f_n : X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, we say that f_n converges pointwise to $f : X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ if $\forall x \in X$, $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} f_n(x) = f(x)$.
Equivalently, $\forall x \in X$, $\forall \varepsilon > 0$, $\exists N = N(x, \varepsilon)$ such that for all $n \geq N$, $|f_n(x) - f(x)| < \varepsilon$.
- (10) Uniform convergence $f_n \rightarrow f$ means $\sup_x |f_n(x) - f(x)| \rightarrow 0$. The important distinction from pointwise convergence is that the same bound works for every x .

Therefore, uniform convergence can still be used when the point $x = x_n$ depends on n .

- (11) For an operator such as $L(f) = 3f + 2f'$, differentiation lowers the degree of a polynomial by one. This allows the coefficients of a desired preimage to be determined recursively from the highest-degree coefficient downwards, which can establish surjectivity.
- (12) Two permutations in S_n are conjugate exactly when they have the same cycle type. If $\sigma^3 = e$, every cycle of σ has length 1 or 3, so only finitely many cycle types are possible.
- (13) For a matrix A , the infinity norm is $\|A\|_\infty = \max_i \sum_j |a_{ij}|$. Every eigenvalue satisfies $|\lambda| \leq \|A\|_\infty$. Hence if A has nonnegative entries and every row sums to 1, then every eigenvalue has absolute value at most 1.

14th Aug, 2026. Well, I have not been able to find any naturally arising and interesting example of a presheaf which satisfies the uniqueness axiom for sheaves but satisfies the gluability axiom. There is one example where you take the cover of an open set in a topological space X and define the functions to be, say 0 for all $i \in I$, then this would certainly obey the gluability axiom but separability would cause an issue¹.

Also, for a bipartite graph $K_{m,n}$, the automorphism group is isomorphic to the direct product of the symmetric group, $\text{Aut}(K_{m,n}) \equiv S_m \times S_n$. But the questions arises: why the direct product?

Moreover, I had a discussion introducing me to the world to Toposes.

13th Aug, 2026. In algebraic geometry, given an exact sequence of presheaves

$$0 \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_1 \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_2 \longrightarrow \cdots \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_n \longrightarrow 0,$$

we show that the following sequence

$$0 \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_1 U \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_2 U \longrightarrow \cdots \longrightarrow \mathcal{F}_n U \longrightarrow 0,$$

is also exact. Well, this is an iff result and given the definition of a presheaf, which is defined locally, the first exact sequence gives us the second one. We work the other way around by, again, using the definition of presheaves.

12th Aug, 2026. Mathematical ventures on this day included some more reading into scheme-theoretic algebraic notions from Eisenbud, along with some revisitation of linear algebra, particularly diagonal matrices and diagonalizability, and also a result in metric spaces.

¹Please refer to this [link](#) for a detailed discussion of this example.

A diagonal matrix is a matrix whose entries away from the main diagonal are all zero, i.e.

$$D = \begin{pmatrix} d_1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ 0 & d_2 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & d_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

It is interesting that a matrix A is diagonalizable precisely when there is a basis consisting of eigenvectors of A , equivalently when

$$P^{-1}AP = D$$

for some invertible matrix P and diagonal matrix D .

The columns of P are simply the linearly independent eigenvectors of A . If

$$Av_i = \lambda_i v_i, \quad i = 1, \dots, n,$$

then we take

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} | & | & \cdots & | \\ v_1 & v_2 & \cdots & v_n \\ | & | & \cdots & | \end{pmatrix}, \quad D = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ 0 & \lambda_2 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & \lambda_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Since the eigenvectors are linearly independent, P is invertible, and from

$$AP = PD$$

we obtain

$$P^{-1}AP = D.$$

So, essentially, determining P amounts to finding a basis of eigenvectors of A and placing these eigenvectors as the columns of P .

In metric spaces, every finite metric space with n points can be isometrically embedded into $\mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ with the usual Euclidean metric. It is quite interesting to see an abstract finite metric space being realised concretely as a configuration of points in Euclidean space.

Alongside this, $\text{Spec}(R)$ both as the set of prime ideals of R and through the geometric structure given by the Zariski topology is quite interesting.

We can think of

$$\text{Spec}(R) = \{\mathfrak{p} \subseteq R : \mathfrak{p} \text{ is prime}\}$$

as a collection of prime ideals, and also as a geometric object by putting the Zariski topology on it. For an ideal $I \subseteq R$, we consider

$$V(I) = \{\mathfrak{p} \in \text{Spec}(R) : I \subseteq \mathfrak{p}\},$$

and these sets form the closed sets of the Zariski topology. There is also a structure sheaf $\mathcal{O}_{\text{Spec}(R)}$, and together with the underlying topological space, this gives us the affine scheme associated to R .

10th Aug, 2026. Mathematics on this day included some interesting results about groups acting on metric spaces. One such result was that if a group G acts freely by isometries on $\mathbb{R}^n$, equipped with the Euclidean metric, then G must be torsion-free. This is quite interesting since the geometry of the space places an algebraic restriction on the group itself.

In particular, the idea of algebraic sets as zero sets of ideals and the way varieties arise from imposing irreducibility on these sets is interesting.

09th Aug, 2026. Mathematical ventures on this day included some revisits to linear algebra and analysis, for the most part. The theory of matrices is very rich and gives us some very strong results. For instance, the eigenvalues of a matrix whose entries are non-negative and whose row sums are all equal to 1 must all have absolute value at most 1. That is, if $A = a_{ij}$ satisfies

$$a_{ij} \geq 0, \quad \sum_j a_{ij} = 1,$$

then every eigenvalue λ of A satisfies

$$|\lambda| \leq 1.$$

In analysis, the Bolzano-Weierstrass theorem tells us that every bounded sequence in $\mathbb{R}^n$ has a convergent subsequence, extending that the *Arzelà-Ascoli* theorem tells us that under suitable conditions, a sequence of functions has a *uniformly* convergent subsequence. In particular, *a uniformly bounded and equicontinuous family of continuous functions on a compact space is relatively compact in the uniform topology.*

Also the idea that a finite metric space can be isometrically embedded into some Euclidean space $\mathbb{R}^n$ is particularly interesting. Thus, given a finite metric space X , there exists some n and a distance-preserving map

$$f : X \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}^n.$$

08th Aug, 2026. Mathematics on this day included some readings on the realisation of groups as metric spaces. We start by taking a group G and its generating set S . Now, for any two elements $g_1, g_2 \in G$ we define the *distance* between them to be the word length $g_1^{-1}g_2$ with respect to S . This induces a metric on G , referred to as the *word metric*. Well, to be precise, the word metric is defined as

$$d_S(g_1, g_2) = |g_1^{-1}g_2|_S,$$

where $|g_1^{-1}g_2|_S$ denotes the minimum number of generators from $S \cup S^{-1}$ needed to express $g_1^{-1}g_2$. Moreover, when we think of groups in terms of their Cayley graphs, this word metric is precisely the *path metric* of the graph.

Another interesting thing about viewing groups as metric spaces is the analogue of isomorphisms which we obtain in the latter, called an *isometry*. An isometry is simply a bijective function, say f defined as:

$$f : (X, d_X) \rightarrow (Y, d_Y),$$

such that

$$d_Y(f(x_1), f(x_2)) = d_X(x_1, x_2)$$

for all pairs $x_1, x_2 \in X$.

Another interesting notion is that of the group of symmetries of a metric space X , denoted as $\text{Isom}(X)$. And a group action of a group G on a metric space X would then be the following group homomorphism

$$G \rightarrow \text{Isom}(X).$$

So essentially, for each element $g \in G$, the map gives us an isometry $X \rightarrow X$.

07th Aug, 2026. Some mathematics discussions² on this day included an alternate proof of the *Bolzano–Weierstrass theorem*. The idea was to start with a bounded sequence $(a_n) \subseteq [a, b]$, divide the interval into two parts, and keep the part which contains infinitely many terms of the sequence. One can keep doing this, obtaining nested intervals

$$I_1 \supseteq I_2 \supseteq I_3 \supseteq \dots$$

whose lengths tend to zero. One can then choose a subsequence by taking a term from each of these intervals, and this subsequence will converge to the unique point determined by the nested intervals. I particularly liked the rather physical analogy used to explain this.

Also, the *Archimedean property* can be realised through the Tortoise and Hare story, and the *Monotone Convergence Theorem* can be visualised by repeatedly partitioning a bounded interval and narrowing down towards a certain point.

In another news, an algebraic set can be defined using an ideal rather than a collection of polynomials. Given an ideal $\mathfrak{J} \subseteq k[x_1, \dots, x_n]$, we can consider

$$V(\mathfrak{J}) = \{a \in \mathbb{A}_k^n : f(a) = 0 \text{ for every } f \in \mathfrak{J}\}$$

.Moreover, the radical of an ideal has some interesting properties that one can play around with in commutative algebra. In particular,

$$V(\mathfrak{J}) = V(\sqrt{\mathfrak{J}}),$$

which is quite interesting since the algebraic set cannot distinguish between an ideal and its radical.

Modules, on the other hand, generally have two ways of being viewed. While I prefer the ring-action approach,

$$R \times M \longrightarrow M,$$

²Please refer to this [webpage](#) and the notes provided there for these ideas.

I hope to learn to appreciate the linear algebra approach as well, where modules over rings are considered analogous to vector spaces over a field.

05th Aug, 2026. One of the more surprising ideas I encountered today was that the common notion of the zero set of a collection of polynomials is elevated to a central geometric object in algebraic geometry. Such a set is called an *algebraic set*, while a *variety* is, roughly speaking, an irreducible algebraic set (depending on the convention being used).

I also found it interesting that these objects are studied in affine space $(\mathbb{A}_k^n)$. Although affine space has points with coordinates such as $(0, 0)$ or, more generally, $(0, \dots, 0)$, it is not regarded as having a distinguished origin in the geometric sense. The point $(0, \dots, 0)$ is then simply another point of the space, and whether it belongs to the zero set of a polynomial depends entirely on the polynomial itself. For instance, if the constant term is nonzero, then $(0, \dots, 0)$ need not be a zero of that polynomial.

Another pleasing observation was that the Cayley graph of the free group F_2 , with respect to its standard free generators, is the infinite 4-regular tree T_4 . Starting from any vertex, the tree branches outward in a remarkably symmetric fashion, and after the initial four edges, there are $4 \cdot 3^{n-1}$ new vertices at distance n from the starting point.

Moreover, algebraic sets are interesting objects. Although they can be defined over any field, many of their fundamental properties are studied over algebraically closed fields. There is also the *Zariski topology*, which arises naturally on affine spaces and whose closed sets are precisely the algebraic sets, at least for $n = 1$ and $n = 2$.

04th Aug, 2026. Well, the Cayley graph of a free group with respect to a free basis is an infinite regular tree. This graph has some interesting valencies at each point and it is unlike the finite groups' graphs which contain cycles. In other news, $SL_2(\mathbb{Z})$ has some interesting elements which are also its generators. It would be interesting to explore the geometry of its Cayley graph.

03rd Aug, 2026. Today I learned that automorphisms of a group induce automorphisms of its Cayley graph (provided the generating set is preserved). This is interesting because every automorphism of a group is a permutation of its underlying set, so there is a natural embedding $\text{Aut}(G) \hookrightarrow \text{Sym}(G)$. Thus, the same automorphism acts both as a permutation of the group and as a symmetry of its Cayley graph.